

Grown-up's Playbook: The Singing Spring

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Singing Spring: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, but cleverness and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Olive Town.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Wits** (clever thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the golden thread, a small cake or token for the honey cake, and anything at all for a lyre. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Wits and Heart together, say, or Courage and Wits).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these hills, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	A friendly satyr gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A favourable wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Chiron the centaur passes by and nods kindly. All is well.
5	An olive branch for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Lonely Cyclops at the spring is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a giant who has been alone too long. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him, and then by waking the Singing Nymphs with a tune. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Singing Spring: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Riddle Gate (Normal)

The challenge. The Riddle Sphinx will not open the gate until the players answer her riddle. She is fair and patient, and she enjoys a good thinking face.

The riddle. Read it aloud: *"I have roots that nobody sees. I am taller than the tallest trees. Up, up, up I go, and yet I never grow. What am I?"* The answer is **a mountain** (think of Olympus rising above you).

Intended solution. This is a thinking challenge of Wits and a little Vocabulary. Let the children talk it through together. The sphinx accepts the right answer, and because she is kind, she also accepts a brave, thoughtful guess.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the sphinx offers a clue ("You can see me from your town, and the gods live on my head"), or Bramble the satyr whispers the answer from behind a rock. A guess made bravely still opens the gate.

Stop 2: The Winding Maze (Normal)

The challenge. Beyond the gate is a maze of stone walls where every path looks the same. The players must find their way through without getting lost.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Logic moment. The clever move is to use the **golden thread**: tie one end at the entrance and unspool it as you go, so you can always retrace your steps and never walk the same wrong path twice. Marking each turn, or asking **Bramble the Satyr** for a hint, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Bramble pop up and point the way with a joke, or let them spend an energy star to "remember" the route. Getting through with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Lonely Cyclops (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. A huge one-eyed giant sits in front of the spring with his arms folded. He looks fearsome, and the players may feel this is a fight. It is not.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Courage moment. The giant is simply lonely; nobody ever visits him. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **honey cake**, asking his name, telling him he is not alone, inviting him to be a friend. When the children are kind, he moves aside with happy tears. Then they wake the spring by playing the **little lyre**, and the **Singing Nymphs** rise and sing.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the giant sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Are you scared of me too?" A single kind word melts him. The moment the players try any tune at all, the nymphs wake and the water sings.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the spring sings, every well in the Olive Town fills again, the giant has friends at last, and wise **Athena** smiles down from the mountain. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.